scientific and philosophical school to which he soon affiliated a young disciple, Democritus, whose long shadow was to be cast over the thought of all subsequent times.

Together, these two thinkers have built the majestic cathedral of ancient atomism. Leucippus was the teacher. Democritus, the great pupil who wrote dozens of works on every field of knowledge, and was deeply venerated in antiquity, when people were familiar with these works. ‘The most subtle of the Ancients’, Seneca called him.[3] ‘Who is there whom we can compare with him for the greatness, not merely of his genius, but also of his spirit?’ asks Cicero.[4]

What, then, had Leucippus and Democritus discovered? The Milesians had understood that the world can be comprehended using reason. They had become convinced that the variety of natural phenomena must be attributable to something simple, and had tried to understand what this something might be. They had conceived of a kind of elementary substance of which everything was made. Anaximenes, among the Milesians, had imagined this substance could compress and rarefy, thus transforming from one to another of the elements of which the world is constituted. It was a first germ of physics, rough and elementary, but in the right direction. An idea was needed, a great idea, a grand vision, to grasp the hidden order of the world. Leucippus and Democritus came up with this idea.

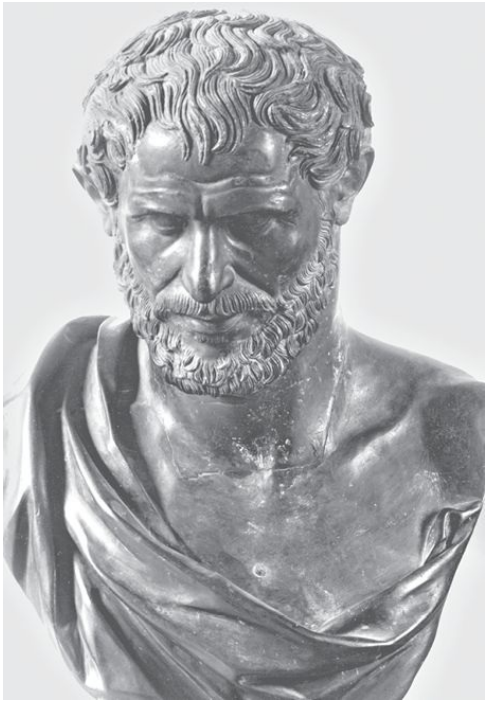


Figure 1.2 Democritus of Abdera.